Changes Worth Writing Down: Twelve Everyday Events to Notice and Mention When You're Planning Ahead for Dad

Everyday changes in money, home, care and family to notice and note, with no interpreting.

A move to a smaller place. A house sold. A check from an aunt's estate. In most families these are just news, and nobody thinks to jot them down. This guide names twelve everyday changes worth noticing while you're planning ahead for Dad and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. Dad isn't on Medicaid, and nothing here says he will be. Whether any of these would matter if he ever needed it depends on his state and his situation, and that is a question for a professional. The general point comes from the nonprofit Justice in Aging: changes in a person's life, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income, can change Medicaid eligibility. The list of changes follows the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The record-keeping details follow the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, the point about the mail follows the federal renewal flyer, and the wording about what to write down is ours.

Income and accounts

1 A change in income [1]

NOTICE A pension starting or stopping, Dad giving up part-time work, a new monthly payment, rent coming in from a property.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the month it started, and where the letter or statement about it is.

2 An account opened, closed or changed

NOTICE A new account, an old one closed, two combined, or a name added or taken off.

WRITE DOWN Which account, what changed, the date, and who made the change.

3 A large or unusual transaction [2]

NOTICE A big withdrawal, a major purchase, or a check nobody can place when the statement comes.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount, what it was for, who was paid, and where the receipt is.

Property and money that arrives

4 A sale

NOTICE The house, a piece of land, a cabin or a vehicle being sold, or talk of selling.

WRITE DOWN What it is, whether it's talk or a plan, and a rough date.

5 An inheritance or a gift

NOTICE Dad named in a relative's will, an estate being settled, or money or something of value given to him.

WRITE DOWN Who it's from, what you know about the timing, and whether it has arrived.

6 Insurance money, a refund or another surprise

NOTICE An insurance payment, a large refund, or any money nobody planned on.

WRITE DOWN What it is, where it came from, the date, and where it is now.

Home and care

7 A move [1]

NOTICE Talk of a smaller place, moving in with family, moving nearer one of the children, or moving to another state.

WRITE DOWN Where from, where to, which state, and a rough date.

8 Someone moving in or out

NOTICE A relative or a friend moving in with Dad, or someone who has lived with him leaving.

WRITE DOWN Who, since when, and how the household bills are shared now.

9 A change in his health or in the help he gets

NOTICE A change in Dad's health, a helper starting to come in, a family member doing more than before, talk of a different place to live with more care.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and who helps with what.

Family and paperwork

10 A marriage or another change in the family

NOTICE A marriage, a divorce, a death in the family, or the family member who helps most moving away.

WRITE DOWN What changed and when, and whether it changes who helps Dad with what.

11 Legal papers signed, updated or moved [3]

NOTICE A legal document signed or changed, a visit to an attorney, or papers moved to a new drawer or a safe-deposit box.

WRITE DOWN What the document is, its date, where the original is kept, and who knows where to find it.

12 The mail, and who opens it [4]

NOTICE A change of address, mail forwarded or going to a son or daughter, statements switching to online only.

WRITE DOWN Where each kind of mail goes now, since when, and who opens it.

When to mention it before acting

For most of these, a dated note is the family's part, and it goes in the folder for the next review. A significant change in Dad's health, care or finances is one to mention to your Medicaid planner when it happens. And when someone is about to act on a change, such as a sale, a move, or a decision about money that has arrived, bring it, with your note, to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney first. A question about a financial or insurance product goes to a licensed financial or insurance professional. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these means for Medicaid, whether one would have to be reported, or how it would be treated. It doesn't grade your family's situation or predict that Dad will need Medicaid. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know which everyday changes to write down, and you may already have a few on paper. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage